

Workloading & Crew Sizing

Workloading turns square footage and a scope of work into a realistic nightly plan: how many hours, how many people, and in what order. Get it right and the crew finishes on time every night. Guess, and the building tells on you.

What Workloading Is

Workloading is the industry's method for calculating how long a building takes to clean. It is simple math built on production rates: how many square feet one trained person can clean in one hour for a given task. ISSA (the worldwide cleaning industry association) publishes the standard rates, and the industry average across all building types is about 3,289 sq ft per hour per person for a full scope clean.

THE TWO FORMULAS

Area time: square feet ÷ production rate × 60 = minutes per visit.

Restroom time: total fixtures (toilets + urinals + sinks) × 3 minutes. Restrooms are always calculated separately because they are fixture driven, not square foot driven.

Production rates are benchmarks, not laws. Adjust for your building: medical protocols add 20 to 30 percent, high density offices add 15 to 20 percent, and a brand new account runs 15 to 20 percent slow for the first few weeks while the crew learns the building. That first night slowness is normal and expected.

Do Your Research First

Workloading is only as good as the walk through behind it. Before you plan a single hour, walk the building with the scope of work in hand and collect:

- ☐ Cleanable square footage (skip mechanical rooms, storage, and shafts; a typical office is 85 to 90 percent of gross)
- ☐ Restroom count and total fixtures: toilets, urinals, and sinks
- ☐ Floor types and rough percentages: carpet vs. hard floor, by area
- ☐ Density and traffic: cubicle farm or open plan, busy lobby or quiet suite
- ☐ Hot spots the client cares about: entry glass, lobby, conference rooms, and the decision maker's office
- ☐ Trash locations, dumpster route, janitor closet, mop sink, and water
- ☐ Access details: alarm, lights, locks, and any after hours restrictions

The Benchmark Rates

BUILDING TYPE	TYPICAL RATE (SQ FT/HR)
Office, standard density	3,000 to 5,000
Office, high density	2,500 to 3,500
Medical office or clinic	1,500 to 2,500
Industrial or warehouse	5,000 to 8,000
Retail	3,000 to 4,500
Education (K-12)	2,500 to 3,500

Task level rates matter when you split the work: a backpack vacuum covers about 4,000 sq ft per hour, a flat mop system about 6,667, trash and spot cleaning runs 16,000 or more, and full detail dusting slows to about 5,000.

A Worked Example

A 20,000 sq ft standard office, 5 nights per week, with 3 restrooms totaling 24 fixtures:

- 1. Restrooms:** 24 fixtures × 3 min = 72 minutes = 1.2 hours.
- 2. General areas:** about 19,200 sq ft ÷ 3,500 sq ft/hr = 5.5 hours.
- 3. Extras:** break room and conference detail, 0.5 hours.
- 4. Nightly total: about 7.2 hours.** That is one person for 7 hours, or a 2 person crew for about 3.5 hours each.

FIRST WEEKS ARE SLOWER

Multiply your first two weeks by 1.15 to 1.20. A 7 hour building runs 8 to 9 hours until the crew knows every corner. Plan for it so nobody panics on night one.

Pick Your Method: 5-Step or Team Cleaning

City Wide standardizes on two proven methods. The building size and crew count pick the method for you.

	THE 5-STEP PROCESS	TEAM CLEANING
Best for	Small buildings, 1 or 2 cleaners	Larger buildings, 3 or more cleaners
How it works	One cleaner completes 5 steps in order, walking the building 4 times	Specialists each master one job and flow through the building in sequence
Built in quality check	Each pass double checks the one before it	Each specialist checks the specialist ahead of them

THE 5-STEP PROCESS		TEAM CLEANING
Efficiency	Fastest way for one person to cover everything without missing items	10 to 15 percent more efficient than zone cleaning in bigger buildings

The 5-Step Process (small buildings)

- 1. Restrooms** (trip 1): stock paper first, then bowls, fixtures, surfaces, mirrors, and finish by wet mopping the whole floor.
- 2. Trash** (trip 1): empty and reline, check under desks, leave the chair out if the floor needs vacuuming. Never throw away anything that is not clearly trash; when in doubt, leave a note.
- 3. Dusting & doors** (trip 2): damp dust desks and surfaces, spot wash doors, frames, and switch plates, square up conference chairs.
- 4. Floor work** (trip 3): vacuum traffic lanes plus flagged spots, dust mop and spot mop hard floors, spot the carpet.
- 5. Inspect** (trip 4): walk the building with the inspection checklist and catch your own misses before the client does.

The separate trips are the point. Checking the building four times catches errors while they are still cheap, and it is faster than trying to do everything in one pass.

Team Cleaning (larger buildings)

Four specialists, each with one clear job, moving through the building on the same track in sequence:

- **Light Duty Specialist** leads: trash, dusting, spot cleaning, and flags floors that need the vacuum by leaving the chair out.
- **Vacuum Specialist** follows the same track: all carpet, traffic lanes, restroom floors, and turns off lights and secures doors behind the team.
- **Restroom Specialist** owns every restroom: stock, fixtures, partitions, and floors. The most detailed job on the team.
- **Utility Specialist** (usually the crew leader): lobby and entry glass, stairs, burnishing, trash haul to the dumpster, and the final walk through.

Why it wins in bigger buildings: one task is easier to learn and master, training a replacement takes hours instead of weeks, less equipment sits idle, and every task gets double checked because the next specialist walks the same path. Specialists build real speed, which is where the 10 to 15 percent efficiency gain comes from.

Setting Up Team Cleaning in a New Facility

- 1. Divide the building** into equal portions sized to the shift. A team working pace is roughly 10,000 to 12,000 sq ft per hour, so a 4 hour shift covers 40,000 to 48,000 sq ft.
- 2. Split each portion into 4 cores** (quads). Core 1 starts at an obvious landmark, and the team tracks through the cores in the same order every night, clockwise or counterclockwise, ending where they started.

- 3. Write assignment cards** for each specialist: start point, route, tasks, and end point. Cards double as instant training for a fill in when someone is out.
- 4. Set locator points:** the plan says where each specialist should be at each time, so the crew leader can check progress at a glance.
- 5. Rotate the detail work:** Monday through Thursday each get a detail core, and Fridays rotate projects (blinds, vents, edges, upholstery).

WHEN SOMEONE IS OUT

Shift coverage in this priority order: restrooms first, then trash, then lobby and entry, then vacuuming public corridors. Everything else can wait a night; those four cannot.

First Night, First Week, First Month & Ongoing

The First Night

- Walk the building with the City Wide Night Manager before starting; review the scope of work, alarm, lights, and closet.
- Agree on the workflow: where the route starts, how it tracks, where it ends. How the crew routes the building is the crew leader's call; the Night Manager's suggestions are there to save you hours.
- Focus on the basics done perfectly: restrooms cleaned and stocked, all trash out, common areas clean, building secured.
- Expect to run long. Night one in a new building takes 1.5 to 2 times the steady state time. That is normal.

The First Week

- Goal: the building at 100 percent within the first week, using the detail checklist below to knock out what the last provider missed.
- Improve the timeline every night; the route should get faster as the crew learns the track.
- Dial in the kit: pad counts, cloth colors, chemicals, and the laundry loop (see the Inventory Planner).

The First Month

- Times settle to the workloaded plan. If they have not, re-walk the building and find the bottleneck; it is usually restrooms or a bad route.
- Start the detail rotation (a detail core per night, projects on a weekly rotation) and the monthly floor work.
- Self inspect nightly with the building checklist; catch it before anyone else does.

Ongoing

- Same track, same order, every night. Consistency is what clients feel.
- Keep the detail and project rotations moving so nothing ages more than its cycle: high dusting weekly, low dusting weekly, blinds a section at a time, baseboards monthly.

- Re-workload whenever the building changes: new tenant, new furniture, new scope. Cards and plans go stale quietly.

What to Expect From City Wide: The First Night & First Three Cleans

New accounts are a partnership. Here is exactly what City Wide does alongside your crew on the first three cleans, so everyone knows what good looks like. There is also a printable checklist version of this section for the clipboard.

Before the First Night

- City Wide verifies keys, alarm codes, and light locations during the day, and makes sure the janitor closet is accessible and stocked.
- The cleaning window is set, usually right after the business closes, so the crew never feels rushed.

Night 1: Learn the Building, Nail the Basics

- The Night Manager (and on larger accounts, additional City Wide support) arrives early, walks the crew through the building, and reviews the scope of work room by room.
- The building gets workloaded together: route, order, and time targets.
- The crew focuses on the basics: restrooms cleaned and stocked, trash out, common areas clean, building locked and armed correctly.
- The Night Manager stays through the clean and finals the building with the crew leader: a full walk through together before lock up.

Clean 2: Tighten the Route, Start the Detail

- Timeline should improve from night 1 as the route gets familiar.
- The Night Manager reviews detail work from the 100 percent checklist below and relays any client feedback from the morning visit.
- Final walk through together again, every night.

Clean 3: Near Target, Building at Standard

- Times should be close to the workloaded plan.
- Detail items keep progressing until the building is at 100 percent.
- The Night Manager finals with the crew for at least the first three cleans, longer for large or complex buildings. Once quality holds, City Wide shifts to regular scheduled visits.

The 100 Percent Building Checklist

Work through this list across the first week to erase what the previous provider left behind:

- ☐ Edge all carpets; move chairs and clean behind and under everything
- ☐ High and low dusting, including under objects (put them back exactly)
- ☐ Spot wash doors, door frames, and light switches

- ☐ Dust all woodwork, shelves, furniture, and desk fronts
- ☐ Scrub wax buildup off baseboards; detail thresholds and elevator tracks
- ☐ Detail the outside of toilets and urinals, base to bowl
- ☐ Wash walls and partitions in restrooms and around trash cans
- ☐ Blinds and carpet spotting as required by the scope